



Voyages of discovery

The first people to cross the world's oceans were not interested in the oceans themselves, but in the land they might find beyond them. They included people seeking new places to live, and others looking for valuable goods to trade, such as exotic spices. But eventually, people began exploring the oceans for their own sake, to map them and to understand them.

Polynesian settlers

Exploring the Pacific

Date 1500 BCE–1100 CE

Object of voyage Settlement

Distance traveled 6,000 miles (10,000 km)

The scattered Pacific islands were settled by people who originally came from southeast Asia. From about 3,500 years ago, they spread from island to island until they reached Easter Island in about 1100. The settlers made their incredible journeys across vast tracts of the Pacific Ocean in big double-hulled sailing canoes, navigating by the stars.

▼ POLYNESIAN TRIANGLE

The Polynesian islanders settled on more than 1,000 scattered islands spread over a huge triangular area of the south Pacific.



▲ VIKING LONGSHIP

Built for speed, Viking longships were mainly used for raiding. The Vikings built bigger ships for crossing the Atlantic.

Viking raiders

Across the Atlantic

Date 1000

Object of voyage Settlement

Distance traveled 6,000 miles (10,000 km)

More than a thousand years ago, the Vikings from Scandinavia were mounting armed raids on the coasts of northern Europe, crossing the seas in their sleek longships. But over time, they began settling in new lands, including Iceland and the southern tip of Greenland. Eventually, they reached Newfoundland on the eastern fringes of North America, settling there 500 years before explorer Christopher Columbus crossed the Atlantic.



▲ EXOTIC GOODS

Zheng He returned to China with military successes, treasure, and exotic goods never seen before. One African ruler even sent the Chinese emperor a giraffe.

Zheng He

Chinese fleets

Date 1405–1433

Object of voyage Exploration

Distance traveled 124,000 miles (200,000 km)

One of the first explorers of the Indian Ocean, Chinese admiral Zheng He made seven epic voyages in the early 1400s, visiting India, Arabia, and east Africa. Unlike European explorers, he had huge fleets of ships, and on his first voyage in 1405, he took a fleet of over 300. They included several nine-masted Chinese junk ships estimated at 400 ft (120 m) long—far bigger than European ships of the time.

Bartolomeu Dias

Around Africa

Date 1487–1488

Object of voyage Trade route

Distance traveled 14,000 miles (22,000 km)

Portuguese explorer Bartolomeu Dias was the first European to sail around the southern tip of Africa into the Indian Ocean. His voyage was sponsored by King John of Portugal, who wanted to find a direct trade route to India that avoided traveling overland. Dias had hoped to reach India himself, but after traveling a short distance along the stormy southeast African coast, his exhausted crew forced him to turn back.